

Parisian life

Enlisting with the French infantry, he discovered that he was not cut out for military life either. He found the discipline and conditions unbearable, and in order to get himself discharged found a way of intentionally catching severe bronchitis. Once out of the army, Satie returned to live with his father until he came of age in 1887, when he moved to the bohemian Montmartre district of Paris. It was here that he began composing in earnest, publishing the first of his *Gymnopédies* for piano. These works of timeless simplicity, purity, and melancholy would be his main legacy, despite his later avant-garde compositions that were arguably more significant. In Montmartre, Satie began frequenting the bars, cafés, and cabarets where the artists, writers, and musicians of Paris congregated. Among them was Claude Debussy, who was making his name as a composer of innovative music in an Impressionist style, and he and Satie struck up a friendship, and a friendly rivalry, that would last until Debussy's death in 1918.

At this time, Satie became involved with the mystical Rosicrucian Order, joining the *Ordre de la Rose-Croix Catholique du Temple et du Graal*, and being appointed official composer and chapel-master. He was a devoted member of the order, but later fell out with its leader Joséphin Péladan. The religious and ritual aspects of the Rosicrucians continued to influence him, inspiring a number of semi-mystical works using his own arcane system of composing (see box). He took to walking around in priestly robes, proclaiming himself as founder, leader, and sole member of the *Eglise Métropolitaine d'Art de Jésus Conducteur*